Slaves in Egypt

Exodus 1–11

The big idea: Abraham's family became a nation of slaves in Egypt. God heard their groaning and remembered his covenant. He sent a reluctant rescuer, and plague by plague he answered Pharaoh's question, "Who is the LORD?"

Before you meet: Read

Exodus 1:8–14 | Exodus 2:23–3:15 | Exodus 5:1–2

Open (5 minutes)

Every family has a story it tells again and again. What is one story your family tells, and what does it say about who you are?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"And God heard their _____, and God remembered his _____ with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob." *(Exodus 2:24)*

Pharaoh answered Moses, "Who is the LORD, that I should _____ his voice and let Israel go?" *(Exodus 5:2)*

"Let my people go, that they may _____ me." *(Exodus 7:16)*

Discuss

1. Israel suffered in Egypt for generations. What does Exodus 2:23–25 tell you about God while they waited? *Exodus 2:23–25; 3:7–8*

2. Moses made excuse after excuse until he said, "Oh, my Lord, please send someone else." Which of his excuses sounds most like you? How did God answer him? *Exodus 3:11; 4:10–13*

3. "Let my people go, that they may serve me." God freed Israel from Pharaoh to serve him. How does that change the way you think about freedom? *Exodus 7:16*

4. Sometimes Pharaoh hardened his own heart, and sometimes the LORD hardened it. How can both be true? Why does it matter that we keep both? *Exodus 8:15; 9:12*

Memory verse

"And God heard their groaning, and God remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob."

Exodus 2:24

Pray

Bring God your own groaning, the burden you cannot lift. Thank him that he hears, remembers, sees, and knows, and that in Jesus he came down to set slaves free.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 15

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Exodus 2:23–3:10 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Exodus 12 and 14–15).

Main points to land

1. God heard, remembered, saw, and knew (Exodus 2:23–25). He came down to rescue his people because of his covenant promise, and the rescue rested on him, not on reluctant Moses.
2. The ten plagues answered Pharaoh's question, "Who is the LORD?" Each one judged a power Egypt trusted, so that Egypt and Israel would know that he alone is God (12:12).
3. Pharaoh hardened his own heart, and God hardened it. Pharaoh was fully responsible, and God ruled over his hardness without ever being its author (Ex. 8:15; 9:12; Rom. 9:17).

Answer key (Observe)

1. groaning; covenant
2. obey
3. serve

Questions people will ask

Is it fair for God to harden Pharaoh's heart and then punish him?
The text says both that Pharaoh hardened his heart (8:15) and that the LORD hardened it (9:12). God put no evil into Pharaoh. He withheld the mercy that would have softened him and gave him over to the hardness he already loved (WCF 5.6). Pharaoh was never forced to sin against his will. Paul faces this same question in Romans 9 and does not explain it away. Admit the mystery, and keep both truths.

Closing prayer

Father, thank you that you heard your people in Egypt and came down to rescue them. Thank you that you hear us too. Set us free from every master that enslaves us, and teach us to serve you gladly. In Jesus' name, amen.